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THIRST AIDS FOR STRAYS

From water bowls placed for thirsty stray animals to coconut shell feeders designed for urban birds, here are two organisations in Chennai finding simple, sustainable ways to help the city's voiceless residents endure the summer **P4&5**



BIRDS READ INVISIBLE MAPS

On World Migratory Bird Day, here is a case study of the Common pochard, exploring possible reasons why this bird could be 'warming up to' birders in the Chennai Metropolitan Area but giving those in Madurai the cold shoulder **P6**

'Signboard at Porur junction is misleading'

S.N. RAJARAM

The image shows the signboard near the flyover at the junction of Porur-Kundrathur Main Road and Arcot Road on Mount-Poonamallee High Road in Porur. It faces motorists coming in from Guindy.

This signboard is incomplete and can be misleading for someone new to this area. Though the directional arrows for Kundrathur, Mouliwakkam, Vadapalani and Kodambakkam are correct, it does not mention that one has to take the service road under the flyover. This gives room for ambiguity. Going by this signboard, a newcomer may take the flyover and will miss the right way. A similar problem existed at the signboard near Vadapalani flyover on Jawaharlal Nehru Main Road (facing motorists coming in from Ashok Nagar) wherein the directional arrow for Kodambakkam was misleading as it did not mention that the service road



needed to be taken. However, it was corrected recently by placing an additional signboard directing motorists to take the service road. An ambiguous signboard can add to traffic congestion. Further, Vanagaram tollgate (also known as Porur tollgate) and Poonamallee which are important points in the vicinity do not find a mention in the signboard near the Porur flyover.

er. Given the significance of these two places, they should find a mention in the signboard. This signboard at Porur junction is an important one as it is located on a State Highway. Many use this junction to go other districts in Tamil Nadu and also to Bangalore. So it should contain adequate details.

S.N. Rajaram is a resident of Saligramam



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Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to down-townfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

'Sewage contamination in piped water'

S. SOURIRAJAN

The piped water supply provided by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply & Sewerage Board to Srini-vasa Iyer Street in West Mambalam

is contaminated with sewage. This is a perennial problem and several complaints to CMWSSB have not yielded the desired result.

S. Sourirajan is a resident of West Mambalam

'New ration shop needed in Koluthuvanchery'



The ration shop in Koluthuvanchery.

R.K. RAVICHANDRAN

The ration shop in Koluthuvanchery (near Nadukulam park) on Bharaniputhur Road in Iyyappanthangal caters to approximately 1,800 card holders. Senior citizens and expectant mothers find it difficult and inconvenient as they have to wait for long hours and are exposed to the elements.

Therefore, I request the authori-

ties concerned to set up another ration shop so that a sizeable number of cardholders from the existing shop can be tagged to the new shop.

Further, this shop lies low from the road and gives room for water-logging during rains. This issue should also be addressed.

R.K. Ravichandran is the founder and president of Iyyappanthangal Bharaniputhur Consumer Rights Protection Society

'These traffic signals in K.K. Nagar are ignored'



Traffic signals were installed at the junction of Kamarajar Salai, Lingam Street and P.T. Rajan Salai (commonly known as Nagathamman Kovil junction) in K.K. Nagar recently. However, motorists do not pay them any heed. Further, driving in the wrong direction of the road is common. This junction witnesses heavy traffic as it provides connectivity to Arcot Road and Jawaharlal Nehru Main Road. The image was taken on May 8, 2026.

PHOTO: VELANKANNI RAJ B

‘Cool hands’ scarce in Chennai

With the mercury shooting up, calls for AC repair experts abound, and many of them go unanswered. A case for making AC technician courses more attractive to youngsters



LIFFY THOMAS

As summer temperatures spike in Chennai, air-conditioner technicians are working overtime, with households and businesses scrambling to install, repair and service cooling systems.

All major service providers note that they are struggling to meet the spurt in demand.

That wheels in a question: is the market being fed with a steady pool of trained AC technicians?

Sundaresan Ranganathan, director, Tamilnadu Advanced Technical Training Institute (TAT-TI), a registered organisation, says the Tamil Nadu Industrial Training Institute started offering a two-year programme in Mechanical Refrigeration and AC in 1985 but the course was discontinued during the pandemic due to poor intake.

Scaled-down versions of the same programme are being offered now, one with a three-month duration, and the other six months, but both struggle to inject sufficient trained technicians into the talent pool.

Polytechnic colleges and service providers have been adapting to attract and retain students and skilled technicians but they



At Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College's lab.

have been facing many obstacles. Ramakrishna Mission Polytechnic College in Mylapore, managed by Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home, runs a free residential diploma programme, affiliated to Directorate of Technical Education. At the end of every semester, the college management offers additional training for their students with its training partners, refrigeration and AC course being one of them.

M. Sugumaran, principal of the College, says students are more drawn towards the automobile and manufacturing sector, followed by product design and as developers in the technology sector.

“Diploma students are not so keen on being a technician, preferring to enter the field in supervisory roles for the three-year programme they studied,” says Sugumaran. He says unlike in the past students there have many other alternative courses that show equal, if not greater promise, so becoming a HVAC technician has lost its charm.

Many such institutions admitted students who completed Class X or Class XII; or even dropouts.

According to a report by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) titled ‘Formalising Air Conditioner Technician Training and Certification in India for Climate-resilient Servicing’, the demand for skilled room air-conditioner technicians will rise to around 2 million by 2036-37.

The servicing sector can play a significant role in helping deal with refrigerant overuse for servicing, and bring operational energy-efficiency closer to the designed benchmarks.

For a ready pool of trained technicians, the curriculum offered at most ITI institutions needs a revision. The report says that content must be co-created with industry participation and updated periodically to respond to changes on account of the refrigerant and technology transitions.

In addition to technical training, focus should also be on imparting entrepreneurial and soft skills such as communication and interpersonal skills. Offering social security to informal AC technicians are among other ways to draw people to the HVAC field.

Role of service providers

From incentives to career opportunities, major service providers are adopting different strategies to retain qualified talent.

Hitachi Engineering Excellence Centre runs training programmes to upskill AC technicians with the latest in the field. Its monthly training programmes conducted at SRM Easwari Engineering College in Ramapuram has employees from its 60-plus franchise partners in Tamil Nadu taking part in it.

Besides a skill development centre that Bluestar operates in Ambattur, it runs a training programme on wheels that goes to the doorsteps of the dealers to train technicians in the latest technologies.

Thirst aids for strays

From water bowls placed for thirsty stray animals to coconut shell feeders designed for urban birds, here are two organisations in Chennai finding simple, sustainable ways to help the city's voiceless residents endure the summer



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

As temperatures rise in Chennai during May, the thirst for kindness rises with it. More than ever, the voiceless residents need acts of human kindness to get through their days. A bowl with water or feed is just what the doctor has ordered for animals and birds that are not pets, and have to fend for themselves through the year; and find regular sources of sustenance dry up during peak summer.

Besant Memorial Animal Dispensary (BMAD) in Besant Nagar is step-

ping up once again with its free community water bowl initiative. In its fourth year, the initiative distributes cement water bowls free of cost to residents, community feeders and animal lovers keen on placing them outside homes and shops and in street corners.

The organisation procures the bowls through donations and sponsors, sourcing them from local nurseries and suppliers before distributing them across the city. This year, BMAD initially procured 150 bowls, all of which were claimed within two days.

“We started this because animals

on the streets simply have nowhere to access water,” says Neeraja Venkateswaran, Head of Operations at BMAD. “Natural waterbodies have disappeared or become inaccessible because of urban development. What happens then is that these animals end up suffering from dehydration, heat strokes, and many of them do not survive something as basic as the unavailability of water.”

Where kindness swells, strangely, challenges abound. The logistics is daunting, observes Neeraja.

“And sometimes people ask for larger numbers, but we have to make sure



Bowls kept ready for distribution at BMAD in Besant Nagar.

everyone gets access fairly. Right now, we are distributing a maximum of one bowl per person. We have now placed another order for 400 more.”

The larger concern lies not in distribution, but maintenance. A neglected water bowl can quickly become unhygienic in Chennai's summer heat.

“People should ensure that the water is changed regularly because stagnant water becomes a breeding ground for mosquito larvae,” Neeraja explains. “And if larger animals like cows or horses come there often, it is better to create a permanent water trough because the cement bowls can break.”

The water bowls can be picked up from the BMAD office from Monday to Saturday between 09:30 a.m. and 12:00 p.m., and again from 02:30 p.m. to 04:00 p.m.

Beyond the bowls themselves, Neeraja believes there are countless small acts that can help animals survive the season. These include offering simple meals such as vegetable broth or chicken broth mixed with leftover rice; creating shaded spaces for animals to rest during peak afternoon heat; if possible, allow community dogs to sit inside gated areas or verandahs for some time during extremely hot afternoons.

For further details, BMAD can be contacted via the official email ID: admin.bmadts@gmail.com. They can also be reached through their official Instagram and Facebook handle: @besantmemorialanimaldispensary.

A coconut bowl crafted for feathered residents



A coconut shell bird feeder workshop was organised by Thuvakkam on May 9 at the NGO's head office in Valasaravakkam, bringing together constituencies across demographic divides. The exercise splices urban bird care and sustainable living.

The workshop introduced participants to the process of converting discarded coconut shells into eco-friendly bird feeders.

“Our main aim is to make sure every terrace has an eco-friendly bird feeder so that birds can also survive during summer,” says Kodama Durga Prasad, executive associate – Programs and Volunteering. He added, “Those who do not have space to hang it on their terrace can make use of the urban forests around the city.”

A DIY project

- Take a dry coconut shell and remove all

the inside flesh

- Wash and sun-dry it completely
- Smooth the edges using sandpaper so it is safe for birds
- Make 2-3 small holes near the rim using a drill or heated nail
- Pass jute rope or strong string through the holes and tie secure knots
- Create a loop at the top for hanging
- Optional: Add a small stick across the shell as a perch
- Fill it with millets, rice grains, broken wheat or sunflower seeds
- Avoid salty, spicy or cooked food
- Hang it in a shaded and safe place away from cats
- Refill food regularly and clean the shell once a week to maintain hygiene



During a coconut shell feeder-making session.



sundaravel / Feb 2

Birds read invisible maps

On World Migratory Bird Day, here is a case study of the Common pochard, exploring possible reasons why this bird could be 'warming up to' birders in the Chennai Metropolitan Area but giving those in Madurai the cold shoulder

PRINCE FREDERICK

"Not even time for birds to fly to southern skies." That is a line from Stevie Wonder's "I Just Called To Say I Love You", a song that has stood the shifting fads of time. And that line refers to an avian pattern that has persisted through time. It hints at birds migrating from the north, escaping its inclement winter to sojourn in the south. While the escape will continue winter after winter, the sojourn can undergo changes of address, depending on local factors, anthropogenic and climatic.

Welcome to the choices made by migratory birds: the how and

Common pochards at Amoor Lake near Chennai in February 2026.
PHOTOS: SUNDARAVEL PALANIVEL

why of it.

Dr. T. Badri Narayanan is an ophthalmologist with an eye for birds, an eye sharpened with some degree of formal training (a correspondence course from Bombay Natural History Society and an ornithology course offered by NPTEL during the pandemic) but largely on account of time spent on the field. He illustrates the possible causes of change in bird migration with his observations of the Common pochard in the Chennai Metropolitan Area and his regular stomping ground, Madurai.

Dr. Narayanan notes that the migratory Common pochard is sighted sporadically in the Chennai Metropolitan Area which includes patches of Kancheepuram and Chengalpet. It is also documented from time to time in other parts of southern Tamil Nadu. He recalls sightings of Common pochard flocks around 15 years ago at Aarpakkam tank near Kancheepuram as well as Ponnur lake, also set in the same geography. During the 2025-26 migratory season, the Common pochard showed up as a flock at Amoor lake, near Sirudhavar in Chengalpet district, not too far from Chennai.

In contrast, birders in Madurai are being stood up by this bird.

For anyone who has birded in the 1980s and 90s, this could be startling as Madurai was a sure-fire destination in this bird's winter itinerary. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a species can change its wintering address if it is up against habitat degradation. The reality in Madurai does not point in that direction, at least not on the surface, and he looks elsewhere for a possible cause.

He observes that globally, the Common pochard's numbers are dwindling and the species has moved from "Least Concern" to "Near Threatened", and therefore, fewer birds migrate deep into peninsular India. The suggestion is that they could be happily "hot-desked" with enough "seats" provided for them in the wetlands of central and northern India.

A migratory bird might change its wintering address for one or a combination of these reasons. One, habitat destruction. Two, food scarcity. Three, climatic changes. Four, population decline reducing migratory spread (the Common pochard's situation in Madurai probably checks this box). Five, availability of suitable habitats earlier on in their migratory route. Dr. Badri Narayanan notes that a cause can be identified only with sufficient data gathered over a long period of time with observations, around 10 years or more. He points out that citizen-science platforms such as eBird can be source for that kind of data.





During the event.

A night of innovation and grit

More than 60 teams were shortlisted for Saveetha Engineering College's overnight hackathon

Recently, the campus of Saveetha Engineering College was buzzing with a sea of students, despite the night having set in.

The college tech society hosted 'HackHustle 2.0', an overnight hackathon, bringing together the brightest young minds from Tamil Nadu for the event that was as much about endurance as it was about technology.

Mohanbabu Balachandran, technology head and vice-president, Rocket India, inaugurated the event and shared practical insights on product development, system design, and user experience.

Of the 4,500 applications received for the

event, more than 60 teams were shortlisted through a rigorous selection process that included PSG College of Technology, Sri Sairam Engineering College, Rajalakshmi Engineering College, Sathyabama Institute of Science and Technology and B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute, said a release.

The teams competed across three critical battlefields: fintech, healthcare, and logistics.

As the clock ticked past 10:30 p.m., teams reached their first major milestone – a formal checkpoint review. Each team presented its progress, outlined implementation status and discussed challenges.

Organising committee members, deployed in

pairs across all three venues, provided on-the-spot feedback to help teams course-correct.

Throughout the night, participants continued working. By early morning, a final round of faculty mentoring occurred.

Faculty members worked closely with teams to refine solutions and strengthen final presentations.

The hackathon was not merely a contest but a platform to nurture problem-solving and endurance.

The participants earned not just competition results, but lasting value in the form of experience, and the memory of a night defined by complete dedication, added the release.

Walking ten feet tall



Topppers in the Class XII examinations celebrate at Government Girls Higher Secondary School in Ashok Nagar. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B

Walk to create awareness on multiple sclerosis

To commemorate World Multiple Sclerosis Day (May 30), a walk to create awareness about Multiple Sclerosis will be held on May 14 at Express Avenue between 5 p.m. and 7 p.m. "Walk In My Shoes" is the campaign slogan. Multiple Sclerosis in India is an emerging neurological concern with an estimated 1.5 to 2 lakh people affected, said a release. Due to low awareness overall, and general lack of knowledge, many patients often delay going to a neurologist. The delayed diagnosis leads to progression as it is a progressive disease, added the release.

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Chetpet lake on April 28, 2026. PHOTO: PRABHU . M

Rise in footfall at Chetpet lake

The Chetpet lake-cum-park is witnessing an increase in the number of visitors as it is summer vacation.

It may be noted, this leisure facility, spread across 15.70 acre, was reopened during the first week of this March following a renovation carried out by the Chennai Metropolitan

Development Authority at a cost of ₹20.16 crore, according to a press release dated March 2, 2026.

The work began in June 2025.

As part of the work, the park features musical fountains, outdoor gym, children's play area, and an open gallery with a seating capacity of 120, adds the release.

Free public speaking workshop

Speak Your Mind, in association with MUN Europe, is organising a free public speaking workshop on May 10, 2026, at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

Open to students aged 6 to 21, the workshop is designed to help participants build confidence, improve clarity, and learn how to structure their ideas effectively based on their individual personality. Parents are also welcome to attend and watch their children perform.

This initiative aims to create a supportive environment where young speakers can develop essential communication skills that will benefit them academically and beyond.

Students can register online in advance, and spot registrations will also be available at the venue on the day of the event.

For more details and registration, Contact: 9962194511

Workshop on fundamentals of EV technology

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on electrical vehicle technology from May 13 to 15 at its premises EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate in Ekkattuthangal. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, the concepts covered in the workshop include: basics of power electronics, fundamentals of EV battery, regenerative braking, EV system architecture, electric motors used in EVs, battery management system, thermal management in EVs, EV powertrain operation, safety in EVs, EV performance parameters, basics of EV control systems, EV



testing, efficiency and standards, EV applications and case studies, advantages, limitations and challenges of EVs.

For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254

Bootcamp for CLAT 2027



Career Launcher, Chennai, is hosting a three-day CLAT 2027 Bootcamp from May 14-16, focusing on reading, reasoning, and test strategy. This will be held at its centre in Abiramapuram

A GK Quiz for CLAT aspirants will be held on May 17. Open to aspiring lawyers Call/WhatsApp 7550 330 159.

Workshops on beekeeping and soap making

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre, Guindy, is conducting a workshop on bee keeping on May 14. Another workshop on making herbal soaps will be held on May 15. According to a press release, participants will learn to make soaps from extracts of flowers, leaves, and fruits. Prior registration is necessary. The sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.



Keeping them cool



Animals at Guindy Children's Park getting a water spray through sprinkler systems set up as part of heat stress management during summer. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B



Planetarium closed tomorrow

B.M. Birla Planetarium of Tamil Nadu Science & Technology Centre on Gandhi Mandapam Road in Kotturpuram will remain closed on May 11 on account of the periodic general maintenance.

However, the permanent science exhibition, Science on a Sphere and 3D Science Theatre will function as usual, says a press release.

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